# 2.
# The Evolution of the Liberation Movements

Nationalist historiography portrays the struggle for liberation as an inexorable unfolding of an heroic past by the nation in process of creation, resulting in ultimate triumph over the forces of oppression. Indeed, the making of a new nation as was required by transitions from colonialism or minority rule entailed the deliberate construction of an historical memory of how the nation had been forged and how it was to imagine itself. Yet while the rigidity of settler colonialism invoked its contradiction in the form of militant nationalist movements, the processes whereby the latter developed were often messy, incoherent, partial, and far from complete: they divided as much as they united. Even so, it is possible to identify the steady evolution of nationalist sentiment and organization across the decades.

## Early currents of protest

Save for the completion of white conquest in northern South West Africa following the defeat of German forces during 1914–15, the 'primary resistance' of African societies to white conquest and their desire to establish Union in South Africa met with failure. The swift formation of the ANC (initially known as the South African Native National Congress) in 1912 by a mission-educated elite represented the first attempt to organize resistance along genuinely national lines, to overcome inter-ethnic divisions, and to secure the support of the chiefly aristocracy.[1] Guided by Christian and liberal precepts, its protestations were made on moral and constitutional grounds. While these actions were to prove 'conspicuously ineffective' in reversing the provisions of the 1913 Land Act and Union,[2] the early ANC managed to position itself as a broad-based organization and as the leading voice of African opinion, even though what was a rather conservative elite was to have difficulty connecting with both an emergent urbanized working class and the large mass of Africans residing on communal land in the Reserves or working on white farms. In Rhodesia, in contrast, the formation of the Rhodesian Bantu Voters' Association (RBVA) in 1923 was overwhelmingly concerned with the problems of the small, emerging African elite. Yet when the efforts of the RBVA and other elitist organizations, such as the Gwelo Native Welfare Association and the Rhodesian Native Association, failed to stop the passage of the Land Apportionment Act of 1931, which like the South African Land Act, instituted a division of land between whites and blacks which overwhelmingly favoured the former, they soon gave

[1] Andre Odendaal (1984), *Vukani Bantu! The Beginnings of Black Protest Politics in South Africa to 1912*, Claremont: David Philip.

[2] Saul Dubow (2000), *The African National Congress*, Johannesburg: Jonathan Ball Publishers, 8.



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way to the Southern Rhodesian African National Congress,[3] formed in 1934. However, although the Southern Rhodesian ANC was to emerge as the major vehicle of mass nationalism in the 1950s, this transition had to await other developments.[4]

African urbanization was an inevitable accompaniment of secondary industrialization. The percentage of Africans living in towns in South Africa increased from 12.6 in 1911 to 17.3 in 1936 and 23.7 in 1946.[5] Nonetheless, urbanization amongst Africans remained obstructed by the migrant labour system and segregationist legislation. Even so, by the 1940s, the Natives Law (Fagan) Commission was declaring the idea of 'total segregation…utterly impracticable', asserting the reality of a permanently settled African urban population and that the migrant labour system could not be maintained in the long run, save on a limited scale.[6]

The expansion of industry set in train a process of African proletarianization and protests against the impositions of settler colonialism. The elitist ANC remained steadfastly aloof from these developments. However, in 1918, the Transvaal ANC was involved alongside the revolutionary syndicalist Industrial Workers of Africa (IWA) and International Socialist League (ISL) in a general strike across the Witwatersrand and in the following year played a key role in pushing the ANC into an anti-pass law campaign. Later that year, IWA/ISL members, linked to the Cape Native Congress, joined the Industrial and Commercial Workers' Union (ICU) in waging a bruising dockers' strike. Subsequently, members of the IWA/ISL failed to gain the support of the ANC for a programme of mass actions, but they were instrumental to the calling of a black trade union conference in Bloemfontein. At this event the IWA and other groupings merged under the ICU banner into 'one great union of skilled and unskilled workers of South Africa, south of the Zambesi'.[7]

The ICU, led by a Malawian, Clements Kadalie, promoted a militant message that reverberated around the country, spanning urban and rural areas. Drawing from anarcho-syndicalist ideas, it invoked the vision of 'abolishing the capitalist class' through one big strike. Although too eclectic to be called truly syndicalist as it was subject to other influences such as Garveyism, 'syndicalism was certainly part of its heady ideological mix'.[8] Nonetheless, for a period the ICU thoroughly eclipsed the ANC with a membership exceeding 100,000. Furthermore, its influence spread to neighbouring countries: to South West Africa, where a branch was formed in Luderitz in the early 1920s, and to Zimbabwe, where the Rhodesian ICU was initiated by Robert Sambo in

[3] Henceforth 'Congress'.

[4] Martin Loney (1975), *Rhodesia: White Racism and Imperial Response,* Harmondsworth: Penguin, 96.

[5] David Welsh (1975), 'The growth of towns', in Monica Wilson and Leonard Thompson (eds), *The Oxford History of South Africa: Volume Two, South Africa 1870–1966,* Oxford: Clarendon Press, 172–243.

[6] Ibid., 190.

[7] Lucien van der Walt (2011), 'Black syndicalists and the radicalisation of the SA Native National Congress (SANNC), 1917–1920: The industrial workers of Africa, the International Socialist League and the left wing of Congress', presented to the conference, 'One Hundred Years of the ANC: Debating Liberation Histories and Democracy Today', Universities of Johannesburg and the Witwatersrand, 20–24 September.

[8] Ibid., 28.



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1927.[9] The latter never achieved the importance of its mother organization, although in its appeal to class interest, it left an important legacy which outlasted its subsequent disappearance, owing to official hostility, in the mid-thirties.[10]

## The ANC: from elite to mass nationalism

The ANC played a secondary role during the social ferment of the 1920s when it was outpaced by more popular movements.[11] Often, in a countryside stalked by rural poverty, these were inspired by Africanist dreams (some stimulated by early Pan-African influences imported by Afro-American missionaries) which resulted in millenarian imaginations of an existence free from white influence. In urban areas, the Communist Party of South Africa (CPSA), formed in 1921, had embarked upon a contentious debate about the relationship between the national question and socialist revolution.

The CPSA's initial programme called for the overthrow of South African capitalism, with white workers as the shock troops of the class struggle. In this vision, questions of racism and national oppression would be resolved under the dictatorship of the proletariat. Emergent national movements such as the ANC were viewed as bourgeois and reformist.

In 1922, white workers, led by the CPSA took part in the Rand Revolt, an armed uprising against the state which called for 'Workers of the World to fight and unite for a White South Africa'. The revolt was bloodily crushed by the government of General Smuts, but at the cost of the defeat of his South African Party at the following election in 1924, when the white working class pledged its allegiance to a coalition of the National and Labour parties. This provoked a bitter struggle within the CPSA over the national question, forcing the Communist International to intervene. At its sixth Congress in 1927, held in Moscow, attended by James la Guma on behalf of the CPSA, it was resolved (in line with a shift in Communist policy regarding how to respond to colonialism internationally) that the national question was the 'foundation of the revolution', whose moving force was the black peasantry allied with but led by the working class. As a result, the CPSA declared its struggle would now be for an 'independent Native Republic', and committed to working with the ANC in order to transform it into a 'fighting nationalist revolutionary organization against the white bourgeoisie and British imperialists'.

La Guma had been accompanied to Moscow by Josiah Gumede, the newly elected President of the ANC, who had been strongly influenced by the ideas of Marcus Garvey, the Jamaican prophet of the gospel of 'Africa for the Africans'. Here began the relationship between the two organizations, which, while undergoing various tribulations, was to endure. The Native Republic policy provided the basis for an alliance between nationalist and socialist forces. Nonetheless, it was strongly opposed by elements within the CPSA. It must be remembered that at the time, although the ANC may have passed as the premier vehicle of

[9] Van der Walt, op. cit.
[10] Loney, op. cit., 93–96.
[11] I draw liberally upon various existing accounts of the rise of the ANC and the Congress Alliance.



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African nationalism, its membership was tiny (rarely exceeding more than a few hundred) and was largely restricted to the small elite and members of the chieftaincy. It was not surprising, therefore, that militants within the CPSA argued that the new line diluted the class struggle. As a result, the CPSA was to be riven by factionalism, with many leading figures being purged. Its membership shrank from 1,750 in 1928 to just 150 in 1935. For some years it ceased to exist as an effective force, not least because of the expulsion of many of those who had played a key role in organizing an early wave of independent trade unions established by former members of the ICU and other activists.

The CPSA's influence had been further diminished by the election of Pixley Seme to the presidency of the ANC in 1930 in place of Gumede, whose association with the Communists had alarmed the movement's establishment. Seme's election was only secured amid bitter debates, with more radical elements accusing the leadership of undue timidity in the face of new segregationist measures proposed by Prime Minister J.B. Hertzog. Over the next few years, the ANC was weakened by divisions along factional, regional, and ethnic lines, allowing itself to be eclipsed in its opposition to Hertzog's 'Native Bills' in 1936 by a specially constituted All Africa Convention (AAC). Ironically, this worked to the ANC's good fortune, for although the ANC cooperated closely with the AAC, the Convention was to become identified with a much reviled compromise it made with Hertzog which involved the sacrifice of the principle of the African franchise. Nonetheless, although the ANC was spared the major force of criticism, the failure of the politics of negotiation to prevent the passage of the Native Bills opened the way to intellectual and political renewal.

Phil Bonner argues that the key to the survival of the ANC lies in its attempts throughout its history to mobilize and unite often conflicting constituencies – traditional leaders, the Christianised elite, the urban masses, and the rural population, alongside the diverse ethnic groups distributed amongst the four provinces. Nonetheless, during its early decades, its successes were uneven: in the Reserves, the ANC was viewed as largely irrelevant (until the election of Albert Luthuli, a chief, as President of the organization in 1952), and the urban masses were largely excluded from at least the early part of its history. Indeed, the ANC survived largely because it was galvanized into action by government attempts, as in 1936, to further restrict the rights of Africans.[12] Nonetheless, during the 1940s, the ANC began its transition from an organization of the African elite to one engaged in a mass-based politics.

Under the leadership of A.B. Xuma, who became President in 1940, membership increased to 4,000. Even so, the ANC remained aloof from numerous expressions of social unrest, such as bus boycotts and the formation of squatters' movements. These were the signs of a surge in working class activity and reflected multiple impulses. One was increased levels of urbanization, but this also signified a 'silent revolution' whereby the growing presence of African women in townships led to their becoming a major force within an increasingly urbanized ANC. Indeed, the 1940s was the decade when township Africans demanded to be regarded as urban.[13] Furthermore, African workers

[12] Phil Bonner (2011), Plenary presentation to the conference 'One Hundred Years of the ANC: Debating Liberation Histories and Democracy Today', 20–24 September.

[13] Ibid.



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were not shy in exercising their new economic muscle, acquired during the Second World War. Whereas 171,088 African man-hours had been lost to industry in the period 1930–39, some 1,684,915 were lost in the following decade, reflecting the rapid growth of militant African trade unions and the recovery of the CPSA, which (after the ignominy of supporting the Soviet-Nazi pact) looked to build a united front against fascism. This included its cooperation with the ANC on various issues, notably the formation of an African mineworkers' union and an anti-pass law campaign in 1943–44. Leading members of the CPSA were elected to the ANC's National Executive. Collaboration was strengthened by the massive strike by 100,000 African mineworkers in 1946 which, although defeated, constituted a significant moment in the ANC's turn to mass politics.

Even so, the ANC's top leadership remained suspicious of militant action. This was to change with the establishment of the Youth League in the early 1940s, when young radicals (key individuals amongst whom, such as Nelson Mandela and Walter Sisulu, had been politicized at Fort Hare University College, the sole such institution for African students) challenged the movement's conservative establishment, eventually toppling Xuma and replacing him with Dr James Moroka. In 1949 the Youth League secured adoption by the ANC as a whole of its Programme of Action, which committed it to the achievement of 'national freedom' and mass action. Yet relations between the Youth League and the CPSA were far from easy. In 1947 a pact between Xuma and Drs Naidoo and Naicker of the newly radicalized Natal Indian Congress had signified growing awareness of the need for all oppressed groups to unite, yet the Youth League remained suspicious of communist and non-African influence. However, the coming to power in 1948 of the NP, dedicated to a re-invigoration of white supremacy, concentrated minds and encouraged the ANC to strike up broad alliances. This set the scene for the mass-based protests of the 1950s and the formation of the Congress Alliance.

The government embarked upon its own programme to curtail black political activity. A flurry of legislation, including passage of the Suppression of Communism Act of 1950 which outlawed the CPSA, defined virtually any form of protest as communist and gave the state sweeping powers to suppress opposition. These measures brought forth a counter-movement: the emergence of stay-aways from work and boycotts as major forms of protest.

The most notable campaign was the 1952 Defiance Campaign against Unjust Laws, whereby the ANC sought to implement its Programme of Action through passive resistance. Although broken by state repression, it generated massive support for the ANC whose membership shot up from just 7,000 to nearly 100,000 over a few months. Significantly, too, it increased coordination between the ANC and the Indian Congress, the (Coloured) African People's Organization, and the Council of Non-European Trade Unions. In addition, following the CPSA's enforced dissolution in 1950, many African communists joined the ANC, many devoted themselves to the trade union movement, and white communists formed the Congress of Democrats, while the party itself cautiously re-established itself underground as the South African Communist Party (SACP) in 1953. Also important was the formation in 1955 of the South African Congress of Trade Unions (SACTU) which brought together a complicated mix of racially divided unions. Much influenced by communist theorizing,



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it adopted a strategy which argued that struggles for economic rights could not be distinct from those for political rights.

Via the Defiance Campaign, the evolving Congress Alliance sought to test the limits of mass civil disobedience, its aim being to clog the jails with protestors and to bring the administration of unjust laws to a halt. Acts of defiance took place in many towns and cities and provoked direct confrontation with the authorities. However, while this created a powerful political legacy, the state itself responded to mass action by elaborating its repertoire of repression. This included a series of banning orders and arrests which decimated the Congress Alliance leadership. Not one unjust law was repealed, and the government's heavy-handed response enabled it to increase its majority in the election of 1953.

All this compelled the ANC and its allies to rethink their strategy, culminating in the convening of the Congress of the People in June 1955 at which some 3,000 delegates adopted the Freedom Charter. This called for all people to be equal before the law and for 'the people to govern'. Controversially, it called for the common ownership of the country's mineral wealth, banks, and monopolies. It was this provision which (after the police had broken up the Congress on its second day) encouraged the state to use the Freedom Charter as the basis for a charge of treason against 156 leaders of the Congress Alliance. Although the five-year Treason Trial was to end ignominiously for the state with the acquittal of the accused, it had the important effect of taking the large body of the leadership of the mass movement out of political circulation during a period when mass action was developing.

Although the Congress Alliance provided a framework for collaboration between different political tendencies, mutual suspicion remained. A key outcome was the split from the ANC in 1958 of an Africanist faction. Led by Robert Sobukwe, the Africanists proclaimed that the ANC had abandoned the African nationalism of the 1949 Programme of Action, and had become the tool of whites and communists. In 1959, they formed the Pan-Africanist Congress (PAC), which repudiated the Freedom Charter alongside any idea of cooperation with any member organizations of the Congress Alliance. Influenced by Ghana's attaining independence in 1957 under Nkrumah, the PAC's commitment to Pan-Africanism appealed to wider African support during the early era of African independence, while its anti-communism positioned it to lure Western support as the Cold War intensified.

The ANC and PAC were drawn into outright competition. In March 1960, the PAC staged a protest against the pass laws a week in advance of a similarly planned action by the ANC. When a crowd of protestors converged on a police station at Sharpeville, in the industrial area of Vereeniging south of Johannesburg, police shot and killed 69 people and injured another 180. A wave of protest reverberated around the country. The scene was now set for a denouement. The regime clamped down heavily upon all mass-based political parties, banned both the ANC and PAC, and proclaimed a State of Emergency. However, it suffered a humiliating setback the following year with the acquittal of all those accused in the Treason Trial. But this convinced key actors within the ANC, notably Nelson Mandela, that the regime was impervious to all forms of legal and non-violent protest. Indeed, for many political activists, the banning of the ANC in 1960 signified the failure of non-violent resistance as a strategy for



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undermining state power and for persuading sufficient whites to abandon apartheid.

The violent crackdown upon the mass movements finally turned the tide. Thus was born, in 1961, Umkhonto we Sizwe (MK), with Mandela as its Commander-in-Chief, as the military wing of the ANC. Its early actions, experimental and amateurish, were directed at sabotage of state installations, designed to signal that the ANC was still active, and a last despairing appeal to whites to turn away from intransigence. The state responded with yet more draconian action, culminating in the arrest of the ANC's underground high command at a farm in Rivonia outside Johannesburg in 1963. The conviction of these leaders, in 1964, to long terms of imprisonment signified the government's determination to smash opposition and left the mass movement leaderless and dispirited. It also cleared the ground for the regime to implement its plan for dividing Africans along ethnic lines via the creation of homelands, the first of which, the Transkei, acceded to 'self-government' in 1963 before proceeding to 'independence' in 1976.

## Popular struggle and divided nationalism in Zimbabwe

The developments in South Africa reverberated throughout the region. In Rhodesia, African urbanization during and after the Second World War had laid the basis for a wave of labour militancy. The Rhodesian Railways African Employees' Association was formed in Bulawayo in 1944. The following year, some 2,400 African railway workers went on strike, the action rapidly spreading to other railway centres in both Rhodesias and lasting for two weeks before being called off by a government promise to investigate grievances. Then, in 1948, a general strike broke out, starting amongst municipal workers in Bulawayo before spreading to every urban and mining centre in the country. The strike attracted the support of other organizations, notably the Congress, which played a role in the negotiations with government that brought it to an end.[14]

African workers were subject to severe controls. In 1934, under pressure from white workers, the government had passed an Industrial Conciliation Act which excluded Africans from being defined as 'employees', and barred them from engaging in collective bargaining. However, the 1945 railway strike resulted two years later in the passage of a Native Labour Boards Act. This prescribed conditions of employment for Africans in all industries except agriculture and domestic service, although Africans were still denied the right to negotiate directly with their employers. However, the continuing growth of African trade unionism during the 1950s forced the government to reconsider. In 1959 a revised Industrial Conciliation Act was passed which now referred to all workers, save (again) African workers in agriculture and domestic service, alongside public servants, and employees of the railways, who were separately catered for in terms of a Railways Act. Although this opened up union-management negotiations for a limited number of skilled workers, the conditions of African workers continued to be largely regulated by industrial boards.

[14] Loney, op. cit., 99–100.



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Unions were allowed to represent workers only in single industries and were precluded from affiliation to any political party.[15]

A key change was foreshadowed in 1958 with the report of an Urban Affairs Commission which stressed the importance of stabilizing industrial labour. This was endorsed by the government, which pronounced that it would encourage permanent settlement by African families in urban areas. Thereafter, the government restructured labour legislation to allow Africans to participate directly in institutionalized wage negotiations, opened up apprenticeships to Africans, and allowed Africans access to previously reserved positions in the civil service. Yet, just as the Fagan Commission had preceded the defeat of Smuts in 1948, so this new commitment to labour stabilization in Zimbabwe was to be reversed, for with the election of the RF in 1962, government lay in the hands of a party which believed in the perpetuation of migrant labour and rural dependency. This had the significant effect of slowing the growth in black industrial workers' wages, which had increased significantly between 1945 and 1962.[16]

Growing worker militancy was matched by a radicalization of African politics which now reached into the countryside. A catalyst was the passage of the Native Land Husbandry Act of 1951 which forced rural families to reduce their cattle herds and change their land tenure practices. Benjamin Burombo, leader of the British African Voice Association, was the most active figure in opposing this hated legislation, and influenced many who were soon to emerge as nationalist leaders. Amongst the latter were James Chikerema, George Nyandoro, and Edson Sithole who together formed the City Youth League in Salisbury in August 1955, later changing its name to the African National Youth League. This represented a challenge to those amongst the African elite who were prepared to work with the imperial scheme to create the Central African Federation (of the two Rhodesias and Nyasaland), which would inevitably have been dominated by the white regime centred in Salisbury. The Federation, created in 1953, supposedly inaugurated a politics of 'partnership', but was bitterly opposed by the majority of Africans in all three territories. Amongst those active in opposing the Federation was Joshua Nkomo. Educated in Rhodesia and trained at tertiary level in South Africa, he had returned home in 1947 to work for the Rhodesian Railways Employees' Association. He went on to revive Congress, which had become largely moribund, and participated in the All Africa Convention that campaigned against the Federation. He went on to stand for election to the Federal parliament in 1953, but was rejected by the overwhelmingly white electorate.[17]

As in South Africa, the Youth League galvanized African politics through strategies of mass action, its most notable triumph being its organization of an effective three-day boycott protesting against a rise in bus fares in August 1956. In 1957, the Youth League merged with the Bulawayo ANC to launch a revitalized national ANC with Nkomo as its President. When Garfield Todd, who had emerged as Prime Minister of Southern Rhodesia with the creation of the

[15] David Martin and Phyllis Johnson (1984), *The Struggle for Zimbabwe: The Chimurenga War*, London and Boston: Faber & Faber, 59–60.

[16] Peter Harris (1975), 'Industrial workers in Rhodesia, 1946–1972', *Journal of Southern African Studies*, 1: 2, 139–61.

[17] Richard Gibson (1972), *African Liberation Movements: Contemporary Struggles against White Minority Rule,* London: Oxford University Press, 158.



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Federation, was removed by a cabinet revolt in 1958 because of his relatively liberal politics, a number of Africans who had worked with his United Federal Party (UFP) now joined Congress.

Any illusion of 'partnership' was finally shattered when large-scale protests in Northern Rhodesia and Nyasaland led to proclamation of a State of Emergency throughout the Federation. Then, in February 1959, Congress in Southern Rhodesia was banned, 500 members arrested, and 300 detained. Nkomo, however, was out of the country, having travelled to Accra in December 1958 to represent the ANC at the First All-African People's Conference before proceeding to Cairo, where he learnt of the imposition of the Emergency. For the next year he remained abroad, seeking to rally support while giving assurances to the British government of his reasonableness. Yet although the British were in the throes of transferring power to appropriately moderate governments elsewhere in Africa, they were not prepared to intervene forcefully in Zimbabwe, where the settlers remained in firm control.

Nkomo had assumed the presidency of the National Democratic Party (NDP), which replaced the banned Congress, in October 1960. His influence was its zenith, and he led his party into constitutional talks in Salisbury in early 1961. The NDP had agreed to insist on parity between African and European seats in a reformed Legislative Assembly. Instead, Nkomo agreed to proposals which would have left Africans with just 15 seats to 50 for Europeans, with the races voting on separate electoral rolls. The NDP executive was outraged and decided to boycott a constitutional referendum which was won handsomely by Sir Edgar Whitehead, who had succeeded Todd as Prime Minister. Under pressure from London, Whitehead announced proposals to reform the Land Apportionment Act, to get more Africans on to the voting roll. But he also banned the NDP for refusing to recognize the new constitution – only for the NDP to reappear as the Zimbabwe African People's Union (ZAPU) with Nkomo as its president once more. ZAPU proceeded to boycott the 1962 elections, at which 14 of the UFP's 35 seats were won by Africans. But by now the RF had been formed to contest 'forced integration', and it swept to power.

Although ZAPU looked to Britain to force the settlers to give way, it recognized the likelihood of its being banned. Indeed, some within ZAPU now argued the necessity of turning to armed struggle, and a first group of young recruits was sent abroad to begin military training in Algeria, China, Czechoslovakia, and Ghana. On their return to Zimbabwe they were to form the first cadres of the Zimbabwe Liberation Army, and initiated various forms of low-scale violence, although publicly, ZAPU was forced to deny any connection with them. It was to be four years before guerrilla warfare was launched, but when it came, it was the newly formed Zimbabwe African National Union (ZANU) which led the way.[18]

The ban on ZAPU came in September 1962. Again, Nkomo was out of the country (lobbying for support from the newly formed OAU whilst his fellow leaders were placed under restriction). In April 1963 he persuaded his colleagues to attend a meeting in Dar es Salaam to discuss establishing a government in exile, but Tanzanian President Julius Nyerere advised him to return home. This acted as catalyst to those who wanted a stronger resistance

[18] Ibid., 161.



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to settler power, and who viewed Nkomo's leadership as obsessed with international diplomacy rather than organizing resistance. The upshot was the formation of ZANU in August 1963, with Ndabaningi Sithole as its first President and Robert Mugabe as its Secretary-General.

Mugabe, born and educated at a Roman Catholic mission at Kutama in the Zvimba district, west of Salisbury (Harare), had won a scholarship to Fort Hare, where he studied for three years from 1949, and was much influenced by ANC Youth Leaguers and the Africanist ideology of Anton Lembede while also having his first encounters with Marxism via contacts with members of the CPSA. Thereafter, he returned to Rhodesia where he continued his studies, picking up a second degree from the University of South Africa by correspondence. Then he moved to Northern Rhodesia (Zambia), where he taught at a teacher training college in Lusaka (acquiring yet another degree, this time from the University of London). From 1958–60, he taught in Ghana just after it had achieved its independence. He then returned to Rhodesia in 1960 and threw himself into nationalist politics, swiftly becoming the NDP's publicity secretary before joining with Sithole in forming ZANU. When he was jailed by Smith in 1964, he used the long years that followed to acquire no less than a further three degrees.[19] Meanwhile, he was deeply affected by the death from malaria of his only child in 1966. The refusal of Prime Minister Ian Smith to allow him to attend the funeral is judged by historian Alex Callinicos as having consolidated 'the radical nationalism' which he came to embody after his release in 1974.[20]

Nkomo responded to the launch of ZANU with the formation of the People's Caretaker Council (PCC) as a front for ZAPU. The split 'was over methods, rather than objectives and reflected the greater militancy of the ZANU leaders', for both were strongly committed to the creation of an independent Zimbabwe, both subordinated class to nationalist struggle, and both drew their leadership from a black petite bourgeoisie of teachers and small businessmen, although the labour movement provided ZAPU in particular with a number of its leading figures and a significant urban base amongst workers.[21] However, from the beginning, particular intellectuals such as Sithole, Mugabe, and Herbert Chitepo were to be predominant within ZANU.

A disastrous interlude followed the split as supporters of the rival organizations clashed violently. Undoubtedly, the conflicts embodied a significant ethnic dimension, underpinned by complicated historical suspicions between Shona and Ndebele which were never subsequently absent from relations between ZANU and ZAPU, and later, between ZANU-PF and the MDC.

The response of the government, now led by Ian Smith, was to ban both the PCC and ZANU in August 1964. Nkomo, Sithole, Mugabe, and numerous of their supporters now began more than a decade in detention, leaving behind them those they had sent outside the country to launch the armed struggle, declaring it an 'inevitable development'.[22] Inside the country, despite ZAPU's

[19] Martin Meredith (2002), *Robert Mugabe: Power, Plunder and Tyranny in Zimbabwe*, Johannesburg and Cape Town: Jonathan Ball Publishers, 19–24.

[20] Alex Callinicos (1981), *Southern Africa after Zimbabwe*, London: Pluto Press, 32.

[21] Ibid., 28.

[22] ZANU (1973), 'Zimbabwe: From confrontation to armed liberation struggle', in Olav Stokke and Carl Widstrand (eds), *Southern Africa: The UN-OAU Conference, Oslo, 9–14 April 1973, Papers and Documents*, Uppsala: Scandinavian Institute of African Studies.



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hopes to the contrary, Africans failed to greet Smith's proclamation of UDI in November 1965 with violence. Meanwhile, attempts by independent African states were made to get ZANU and ZAPU to re-unite. When these failed, the OAU reluctantly resolved to recognize both as liberation movements. An enduring era of rivalry had begun.[23]

## The origins of Namibian nationalism and the launch of SWAPO

Opposition to South African rule after 1945 was initially led by Chief Kutako and the Herero Chiefs' Council, a small group of nationalists active in student bodies and in the South West African Progressive Association (SWAPA). During the years since South Africa had administered the mandate, 'the flame of resistance had been kept alive by the tribal chiefs and their councils', pressing land claims and pointing to long-violated treaties made with Europeans. But nothing was achieved, save the chiefs' talking had 'kept alive their peoples' feelings of the injustice done to them'.[24] But matters had begun to change with the formation of the UN in 1948 and its assumption that South West Africa had automatically become a trust territory under its Charter. Accordingly, when in 1950 the South African government announced that it was choosing to ignore the decision of the International Court of Justice that South West Africa was indeed a territory held under international mandate, various Africans managed to testify to the UN's Fourth Committee, joining in with the lobbying already being made on behalf of Namibians by the Reverend Michael Scott, a turbulent Anglican priest who worked hard to remain a constant thorn in Pretoria's side. In 1957, Jariretundu Kozonguizi was sent by the Herero Chiefs' Council to speak before the UN, which was now in regular receipt of petitions from the people of South West Africa.

The educational situation for blacks in South West Africa was dismal, and it was only in 1948 that the first black student finished secondary school and matriculation.[25] However, a few Namibians had been able to attend schools in South Africa, and a select number of those, like Kozonguizi, gained entry to Fort Hare, where they were able to mix with politically active South Africans, and were to be caught up in the upsurge of the Youth League which revitalized the ANC. Upon returning to South West Africa, they established educational and cultural associations which had goals such as improving educational facilities for blacks, reforming the apartheid curriculum, and establishing independent schools. By the mid-1950s, these had crystallized in SWAPA, reconstituted from a South West African Student Body formed in South Africa in 1952. SWAPA hoped to seek the formation of a truly national body out of a congerie of existing political groupings, all of which were tribally based.

After various abortive attempts at unity,[26] SWAPA came together with these groups (except for one representative of Coloureds, which was under the

[23] Gibson, op. cit., 160–64; Martin and Johnson, op. cit., 63–73.

[24] Gibson, op. cit., 119.

[25] Donald Sparks and December Green (1992), *Namibia: The Nation after Independence*, Boulder CO: Westview Press, 24.

[26] Notable in this respect was the formation of the National Unity Democratic Organization, which failed because it was an extension of the Herero Chiefs' Council.



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complete control of the South African government) to form the South West Africa National Union (SWANU). However, whereas the Chiefs' Council aimed to graft a mass movement onto its own system of authority, SWAPA aimed for a new movement transcending traditional loyalties. Friction developed between the two currents, as while the SWANU president, Jariretundu Kozonguizi, sought to distance the organization from tribal politics, the Council felt threatened by the younger, intellectually inclined and more assertive nationalist leaders. Tensions culminated in the withdrawal of Kutako's councillors from SWANU's executive in April 1960.

Contemporary with these developments, a group of some 200 Namibian migrant workers based in Cape Town, many active within the ANC and South African unions, had formed the Ovamboland People's Congress (OPC), whose aim was to improve the conditions of contract workers from Ovamboland. Out of this grew the Ovamboland People's Organisation (OPO) formed in Windhoek in April 1959 under the leadership of Sam Nujoma, who had been fired from the railways for seeking to form a union. Its organizational difficulties were immense. Strikes by the (South African) African Food and Canning Workers' Union in the early 1950s had met with violent repression, and only occasional strikes happened thereafter. Trade union leaders met with constant harassment, and many were imprisoned. Toivo ya Toivo was dispatched to Robben Island for nearly thirty years. Nonetheless, the OPO had persevered, and it succeeded where other ventures failed because, while it primarily focused upon the welfare of workers from Ovambo, it included amongst its aims commitments to wider change and political independence. This was to prove crucial in its transformation into a party drawing on a multi-ethnic membership.[27]

The three currents of resistance represented by the Chiefs' Council, SWANU and the OPO built upon a movement of wider protest which during the early 1950s had launched a defiance campaign in tandem with equal action in South Africa. But what brought matters to a head was a campaign of resistance to forced removals from the Old Location outside Windhoek. The South African administration planned to relocate the residents of the Location in a new settlement called Katatura ('the place where no one lives') more distant from Windhoek, imposing severe financial burdens upon residents in the form of increased travel and rent costs, as well as separating them into ethnic groups. Faced by resistance, the police responded with violence: on 10 December 1959, they killed eleven people and injured many more. Anticipating Sharpeville, the Windhoek Shootings were to earn widespread international condemnation, embarking South Africa on the road to international ignominy and isolation.

After the Shootings, Nujoma had been deported from Windhoek to Ovamboland, from where he left for exile. In Monrovia, Liberia, he met with Kozonguizi, where they signed a letter calling for the merger of their two organizations at home. Nothing came of this, and the two organizations continued on their separate courses, sometimes friendly and cooperative, but increasingly divided by ideological and tribal conflicts (many SWANU leaders being Herero, although wanting to rise above ethnicity and to form a national organization

[27] Gibson, op. cit., 130–34; Peter Katjavivi (1988), *A History of Resistance in Namibia,* London: James Currey, 17–23.



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with a broad base of support). Both groups continued to operate in quasi-legality at home, as well as establishing rudimentary organizations in exile.[28]

In September 1959, Nujoma and other OPO members had participated in SWANU's conference, and he and Louis Nelengani had been elected to its national executive, with the hope that it would become a united nationalist party. However, continuing divisions made unity difficult. Then, in June 1960, the OPO transformed itself into a broader movement, reconstituting itself as SWAPO with Nujoma at its head. Significantly, the formation of SWAPO had the blessing of the Herero Chiefs' Council which feared that the radical young men in SWANU were opposed to the principle of chieftaincy. Meanwhile, although SWAPO sought to incorporate all tribal groups, it retained its strong ethnic base in Ovamboland, a factor which was to prove vital when the movement in exile decided to launch armed struggle.[29]

Initially, both SWANU and SWAPO were recognized by the OAU. However, outside South West Africa, SWANU had become increasingly identified with the personality of Kozonguizi, who aroused conservative anxieties by building close ties with China and becoming a member of the militant Afro-Asian Peoples' Solidarity Organisation. Yet what proved most damaging was Kozonguizi's negative assessment of the prospects for armed struggle and his vocal criticism of those liberation movements which espoused it. Thus when the OAU had been founded, SWANU welcomed its creation, but declined to create a military force under the sponsorship of its liberation committee. SWAPO had no such inhibitions, and by mid-1965 had emerged as the only nationalist organization the OAU would support. SWANU remained active internationally, but was to become increasingly divided by the ramifications of the Soviet-Chinese conflict. Indeed, whereas the Congress Alliance in South Africa had originally pinned its hopes on SWANU, its alignment with the Chinese was to alarm the staunchly pro-Soviet SACP and to provide the basis for alliance between the ANC and SWAPO (despite the latter having considerable sympathy for the Africanist position of the PAC). SWANU's fate was now to decline into international irrelevance. Meanwhile, SWAPO's readiness to commit itself to armed struggle was matched by the importance it gave to representation in Dar es Salaam and other African centres by full-time activists.[30]

In 1959, African foreign ministers had referred the legal status of South West Africa to the International Court of Justice (ICJ) in The Hague. The case was put by Ethiopia and Liberia as founding members of the League of Nations. However, reflective of the vacillation of the UN around the issue of South Africa at this time, in July 1966 the ICJ handed down a judgement which refused to address the substance of the case, declaring that Ethiopia and Liberia had no special right to bring it. South Africa was triumphant, but in October 1966, African states secured a vote in the General Assembly which terminated the mandate, declared South African occupation illegal, and established a UN Council for South West Africa to administer the territory until independence. For SWAPO, this provided the international legitimation it needed for its turn to

[28] Gibson, op. cit., 122.
[29] Ibid., 132.
[30] Ibid., 134. Gibson discusses how Kozonguizi's pro-Chinese position led to divisions within SWANU, eventually leading to his resignation. However, Nujoma remained on friendly terms with him, and even offered him a position with SWAPO, an offer which Kozonguizi declined.



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armed struggle.[31] To avoid weakening its international position, the administration left SWAPO unbanned, although hemming it in with oppressive restrictions which helped swing the balance of authority within the organization towards the leadership in exile.

## The stamp of history

Settler colonialism imposed similar patterns of white domination on South Africa, Namibia, and Zimbabwe, yet did so in a manner that was highly asymmetrical. Unsurprisingly, it evoked nationalist responses which, whilst feeding into each other, were also uneven and differed in form.

The formation of the ANC in South Africa was a deliberate effort by the early African elite and chiefs to construct an African nation across the boundaries of ethnicity. Nonetheless, up to the 1950s, the ANC was scarcely a national movement. It was dominated by an African elite deeply concerned to maintain respectability; it was largely cut off from the urban masses; and its tenuous links to the rural population in the reserves were filtered through the chiefs. Even so, it displayed staying power, and for all its limitations, it established itself as the premier vehicle for the voicing of African political aspirations.

After the Second World War, the ANC was to be transformed by an internal upheaval generated by the growth of towns and the development of industry which, on the back of heightened levels of working class protest and organization, allowed an urban-based and impatient younger generation to steer it towards mass action. This generation was led by key individuals who had come to political activism through education at mission schools and universities, where they had absorbed heady notions of democracy and African freedom. Vitally, although there were always those within the organization who were wary of, if not opposed to, joint actions with – variously, whites, Indians, Coloureds, and Communists – the ANC forged a tradition which was self-consciously inclusive of other groupings, including trade unions, and individuals committed to the struggle against apartheid. Of course, it proved unable to contain all internal differences – its failure to prevent the split with the Africanists who formed the PAC being the most obvious example. Indeed, even after the breach, there was always a strong Africanist current within the ANC which was deeply suspicious of influences it construed as subversive of African leadership. Nonetheless, while always taxed by the issue of how to work with bodies representative of other races, the ANC proved able to project itself as the principal vehicle of a multi-class, multi-racial alliance, and worked its way towards an imagination of nation which envisaged citizenship for all those who lived in South Africa. In so doing, it offered the prospect that if a democratic society could be established, the distinction between 'settlers' and 'indigenes' could be overcome.

Developments in South Africa were always to have a profound effect upon neighbouring territories, yet the interactions which took place between the ANC and the nationalist movements in Zimbabwe and Namibia were overwhelmingly those of the personal experiences of migrants or activists rather than

[31] Katjavivi, op. cit., 41–58.



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direct organizational linkages. While the project of overthrowing white minority rule was shared, ZANU and SWAPO were less subject to the variety of impulses to which the ANC had continuously to respond. The ANC emerged from struggles within a far more advanced, more complicated, more urbanized, and more diverse society, and its predisposition to embrace difference was a vital outcome. In contrast, while the nationalist elites who formed the core of the liberation movement in Zimbabwe found a significant early base amongst the emergent working class in the major towns, ZANU in particular came to emit a deep suspicion of trade unions and was to root itself more self-consciously amongst the rural population. Further, neither ZAPU nor ZANU proved able to surmount the challenges posed by rivalries which were to revolve as much around ethnic fears and cabals as strategy, and which eventually were to lead to bitter hostility between them. In Namibia, SWAPO was launched to overcome the limitations of ethnicity, but never lost its Ovambo centre of gravity. While heavily based upon the representation of migrant worker grievances, SWAPO's breach with SWANU was to cut it off from nascent traditions of intellectualized militant radicalism. Although the struggles for liberation were closely linked, it was always likely that they would have outcomes which would be as marked by their differences as their similarities.



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